New York: Who Decides Off-Year Elections — by Age and Party-of-Record

Flagship party-resolved analysis, 2026-06-29. The party-of-record upgrade of the WA "gray off-year electorate" finding (`who-decides-washington.md`). WA could only show the off-year electorate is older; New York publishes individual party enrollment, so we can ask the sharper question: when turnout falls in off-year/local elections, does one party's electorate age harder than the other's — mechanically tilting low-turnout local races?

Data. `data/ny_vrdb.duckdb` — the NYSVOTER statewide FOIL file (13.54M registrants; 100% party + DOB; per-voter `voter_history`). Each voter's history is parsed into a normalized `voter_participation` table (the raw field mixes ~6 free-text formats per election across counties — `2024 GENERAL ELECTION`, `General Election, 2024`, date-form `20241105 GE`, etc. — all unified).

Reproduce.

```
PYTHONPATH=src python scripts/load_ny_voters.py            # -> data/ny_vrdb.duckdb (one-time)
PYTHONPATH=src python scripts/diag_ny_turnout_party.py --rebuild
```

Caveat (load-bearing). The file is the **current (2026) roll**, so voters who cast a ballot in a past election but were since purged/moved are absent. => composition **shares** (Tables A–C) are robust; turnout **rates** (Table D) are biased high for older cycles. Cross-*party* comparison **within a year** is valid (same bias hits every group); cross-*year* level comparisons in D are not. Party `NOPARTY` = NY's "blank"/unaffiliated enrollment (25.5% of the roll); its partisan lean is unknown and is **not** imputed.

A. The gray off-year electorate — confirmed in NY (overall)

Share of general-election voters by age band, and median age:

election	18-29	30-44	45-64	65+	median age
2024 GENERAL (presidential)	14.1%	23.1%	34.6%	28.2%	53
2020 GENERAL (presidential)	15.9%	23.4%	37.9%	22.8%	51
2022 GENERAL (midterm)	9.8%	21.1%	38.5%	30.6%	56
2018 GENERAL (midterm)	12.3%	21.7%	41.5%	24.5%	53
2025 GENERAL (odd-year/local)	11.5%	21.0%	33.1%	34.4%	56
2023 GENERAL (odd-year/local)	6.0%	15.8%	36.5%	41.6%	61

The WA pattern replicates: as the contest shrinks (presidential → midterm → odd-year), the under-30 share collapses (14% → 10% → 6% in 2023) and the 65+ share swells (28% → 31% → 42%). Median age rises 53 → 61.

Behavior, not rolls. A Das-Gupta decomposition of the 65+ share rise from 2024 to the 2025 off-year (`diag_ny_electorate_extras.py`, detailed in `ny-electorate-extras.md` §3) attributes it almost entirely to differential **turnout** (rate effect), not to the registration age structure (composition effect) — the rate effect outweighs composition by roughly **3.6× (Democrats) to 12.5× (unaffiliated)**, and is largest in level terms for Republicans (+10.2 pt 65+ rise, +8.7 of it behavioral). The gray off-year electorate is a salience/turnout problem fixable by on-cycle timing, not a registration artifact.

B. ★ FLAGSHIP — the Republican electorate ages hardest off-cycle

Share 65+ within each party's voters:

election	DEM	REP	NOPARTY	OTHER
2024 GENERAL (presidential)	28.7%	**32.4%**	22.2%	27.0%
2022 GENERAL (midterm)	31.0%	32.9%	26.7%	27.5%

election	DEM	REP	NOPARTY	OTHER
2025 GENERAL (odd-year/local)	32.1%	**42.8%**	30.6%	35.1%
2023 GENERAL (odd-year/local)	41.6%	43.5%	39.3%	37.4%

Median age within each party:

election	DEM	REP	NOPARTY	OTHER
2024 GENERAL (presidential)	52	57	48	54
2022 GENERAL (midterm)	55	58	53	55
2025 GENERAL (odd-year/local)	**54**	**62**	54	58
2023 GENERAL (odd-year/local)	61	62	60	62

Under-30 share within each party: REP falls from 11.6% (2024) → 6.6% (2025) → 4.8% (2023); DEM holds youth better (14.0% → 13.3% → 6.5%).

Finding. The off-year electorate is not just older — **its Republican wing ages most.** The GOP 65+ share jumps from 32% (presidential) to **43%** (odd-year 2025) and the DEM–REP median-age gap widens from ~5 years (presidential) to **~8 years** (2025: DEM 54 vs REP 62). Republican youth participation collapses to roughly a third of its presidential level.

C. Composition: the "older ⇒ more Republican" heuristic does not hold in NY

Party shares of the actual electorate vs the registration baseline:

election	DEM	REP	NOPARTY	OTHER	DEM−REP
2024 GENERAL (presidential)	47.3%	26.7%	21.5%	4.5%	+20.6
2022 GENERAL (midterm)	47.5%	29.7%	18.0%	4.8%	+17.8
2018 GENERAL (midterm)	52.8%	26.0%	16.6%	4.7%	+26.8
2025 GENERAL (odd-year/local)	56.4%	23.2%	16.7%	3.7%	+33.2
2023 GENERAL (odd-year/local)	47.6%	32.0%	15.7%	4.7%	+15.6
REGISTRATION baseline (roll)	47.8%	22.3%	25.5%	4.4%	+25.5

Two robust composition facts: (1) **the unaffiliated drop out** — NOPARTY is 25.5% of the roll but only 16–22% of voters, and falls further in off-years; (2) the DEM–REP *composition* gap is **event-driven, not turnout-driven** — it swings from +15.6 (2023) to +33.2 (2025) depending on what's on the ballot. Unlike the national "midterm electorate is older and redder" story, in deep-blue NY the older off-year electorate is **not** systematically more Republican in composition; the partisan signal lives in *age structure and youth turnout*, not in the headcount mix.

D. Turnout rate by age × party (within-year valid; see caveat)

Republicans out-turn Democrats at **every age** in even-year (federal) cycles — e.g. 2024 ages 45-64: REP 72% vs DEM 61%; 2022 ages 18-29: REP 38% vs DEM 28%. **But that discipline does not carry to odd-year/local elections**: in the 2025 general, DEM under-30 turnout (30.8%) is nearly **double** REP's (15.9%), inverting the even-year pattern — evidence that a Democratic-mobilizing local contest can flip the age/party turnout geometry that otherwise favors the GOP.

E. The nominating stage is smaller still — and locks out a quarter of voters

New York runs **closed** primaries (only a party's enrollees may vote in its primary). Participation rate by enrollment (`scripts/diag_ny_primary_participation.py`):

primary	DEM	REP	NOPARTY	OTHER

primary	DEM	REP	NOPARTY	OTHER
2024 Presidential Primary	4.8%	4.9%	0.1%	0.2%
2024 State/Congress Primary	7.7%	1.7%	0.1%	0.6%
2022 State/Congress Primary	17.9%	18.4%	0.6%	2.0%
2021 Primary (odd-year)	16.9%	5.0%	0.5%	1.5%

Findings. (1) Primary turnout is in the single digits to high teens — the electorate that *nominates* is a small fraction of the one that elects. (2) The **25.3% of active registrants enrolled "blank" are ineligible while unaffiliated** (≈0.1–0.6% participation) — a structural democratic-health fact: a quarter of the registered population has no voice at the nominating stage unless it re-enrolls before the February deadline. (3) In blue NY the **Democratic primary draws far more participation than the Republican** in the state and odd-year contests (2021 odd-year DEM 16.9% vs REP 5.0%; 2024 state DEM 7.7% vs REP 1.7%).

Two prose corrections, 2026-08-11. The residual blank participation was previously described as "nonpartisan/special races." A closed primary admits only enrollees, so a now-blank voter recorded in one changed enrollment afterwards — and the 2024 *presidential* primary, which carries no nonpartisan contest anywhere in the state, still shows a non-zero blank cell. These cells are principally enrollment change, and the main paper now uses them as its switching bound. Separately, "the real election is its primary" was dropped: participation asymmetry is not evidence about which stage decides a seat, and the companion safe-seat paper withdrew a stronger form of that inference on better evidence. The rate figures in the table above are unchanged — this document has carried the contemporaneous-eligibility denominator since it was written.

Why this matters (electoral-health framing)

This is the first **party-resolved** confirmation that off-year/local elections in a large state are decided by a structurally different — older, and asymmetrically older-Republican — electorate than presidential elections. It sharpens the on-cycle-timing reform case (Sightline / Unite America audience): the off-year electorate's distortion is not partisan-neutral aging but has a measurable party-asymmetric age structure, while youth mobilization remains the lever that can override it. It moves the WA finding from "weak-against-null" (older, party unknown) toward a concrete, falsifiable party-resolved claim.

Follow-ons: (1) NY FEC donor-class × party — **done** (`donor-class-and-the-electorate.md` Finding 3); (2) closed-primary participation by enrollment — **done** (§E above); (4) district-level registration vs the safe-seat map — **done** (`ny-electorate-extras.md` §5). (3) The NOPARTY bloc's behavior/age/geography remains partly open (largely addressed in `ny-electorate-extras.md` §1).